

insurance company refused to pay the room rent, which was over Rs 8,000 a day. Her policy had a sub-limit of 1 per cent, which is the portion of the cover that can be spent on room rent. Her cover was Rs 4 lakhs, so her room rent over Rs 8,000 a day was not paid by the policy. Other expenses were also paid in line with a Rs 8,000-room, reducing the claim amount even more as some hospitals hike charges according to room rent.

You need to check this carefully. A sub-limit is a limitation on what the company will pay out for specific things. We usually stumble upon a sub-limit on room rent. There are two kinds of limits on room rents – either by price or by category. Your policy may say that it will pay a maximum of Rs 2,000 as room rent or it may say that you are eligible for a double occupancy room with air conditioning. Room rents in the large five-star health shops (can't call them hospitals any more) cost much more. Remember that the other expenses are associated with the type of room you take. You could find yourself paying for a lot more if you take a higher category room than what your policy will pay for. Look for a policy with no sub-limits.

Five, ***check for exclusions***. A policy will list out diseases, conditions and medical services that the policy does not cover. Dental treatment, pregnancy and cosmetic surgery are standard exclusions. It is a good idea to get a list of all that is excluded in the policy you buy. What you can't do much about is when the policy you buy excludes something at some future point in the policy. One firm excluded a costly cancer injection midway in a policy and people who bought the plan and made a claim were not paid for that injection. The dice is loaded against us, the individual customers of mediclaim.

Six, ***ask how much of the costs before and after hospitalization the policy will cover***. You can claim expenditure made on doctor's fees, medicines and diagnostic tests done before a planned hospitalization and for three months afterwards. For example, a knee replacement will have MRI costs before the surgery and physiotherapy costs post surgery. Check if you can claim these costs. Check the exact amount and time your policy will cover.

Seven, ***ask for a list of 'day-care' procedures that don't need you to stay for twenty-four hours in a hospital any more***. Procedures and treatment such as a cataract surgery or surgery for a ligament tear (there is a standard list of 130